

Decomposition

Taking a big, ambiguous goal and breaking it into ordered, doable steps — without being handed a checklist first.

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...break a project into ordered steps without being handed a checklist.	Waits for the teacher to provide a step-by-step list; cannot name a next action independently.	Names a few steps when prompted, but order is incomplete or missing key pieces.	Independently maps out an ordered sequence before asking for help, and adjusts the plan when something changes.	Produces a sequenced breakdown unprompted, flags dependencies or risks, and helps a peer do the same.
...identify which step must come first (the blocker).	Lists tasks randomly with no sense of what must happen before something else can start.	Puts most steps in a workable order but skips at least one dependency (e.g., writing before researching).	Sequences steps so each one sets up the next and can explain why a particular step is the blocker.	Identifies the critical path and redesigns the sequence when a blocker changes.
...size each step so work can be paced.	Treats all tasks as the same effort; no sense of relative size.	Can identify big vs. small tasks but does not connect estimates to available time.	Sizes each step well enough to decide where to start and how to pace across available days.	Estimates effort, builds in buffer for likely problems, and revises estimates mid-project based on evidence.

Proficient = the competency is demonstrated reliably and independently (the target). Advanced = the student extends it unprompted.